

The Olympic motto perhaps comes closest to describing Digit's Zero1 awards this year. With hundreds of the best products in each category vying for Gold, victory has never been sweeter for the winners than this year

In technology, more than in any other market, the race for the laurels is as hotly contested as in the Olympics. Races are won by a hairsbreadth, scores are often tied to the very end, and when in competition, even superb products may fall by the wayside, losing to the mighty.

The difference between the Olympics and Digit's Zero1 awards is that we encourage competitors on steroids and welcome performance enhancers with open arms! This is, after all, technology we're talking about, and performance is a key challenge here. Of course, reliability and reasonable costs also play a big role in our recommendations to our readers.

As the year draws to a close, we recap which products have survived our gruelling tests, shedding the digital equivalent of sweat and blood to emerge as the 2005 champions.

There has been a fair share of upsets this year, as you will see. However, nothing pleased us more than finding out that the predictions we made last year were spot on!

Just a year ago, AMD stole the lime-light with its 64-bit processors, and we predicted that this year would see a shift towards 64-bit CPUs. As you read this, both Intel and AMD are now gradually shifting towards 64-bit computing. What's more, there are already dual-core CPUs from both companies in the market.

This fever hasn't hit only the CPU industry—the GPU community has seen nVidia's SLI and ATI's CrossFire dual-GPU technology really begin to take off. ATI and nVidia have battled it out in the graphics card championship this year, and the result is graphics that make you squeal with delight. Not only did this battle bring us high-end gaming products, it also increased the options for those of us who play in the lower leagues—onboard graphics. Graphics chipsets from ATI and nVidia that can be found even on lower-end motherboards, are better performers than the best graphics cards available just a few years ago!

Competitions were fought not just in the silicon arena, but also between the champions of "iron oxide valley". Hard disk capacities doubled this year, and we actually saw sizes of half a

terabyte! And that's not all—SATA was new to the race last year, but is omnipresent this year, and is already being challenged by SATA II. This has brought amazing amounts of storage at terrific read and write speeds.

As with real-world sportspersons, our contestants, too, got numerous face lifts. Manufacturers have suddenly begun to take the looks of several products—including motherboards and graphics cards!—seriously. And when it comes to lifestyle products, looks are just as important as performance. The drop in LCD prices has helped large-scale adoption of the TFT-LCD monitor. Printers have curves and all-new space-saving designs. Speakers are more powerful and smaller, not to mention a lot prettier!

The year has also seen devices compete inter-category, most notably the mobile phone. Today's smartphones contend head-to-head with PDAs, entry-level digital cameras and MP3 players as well. MP3 players have morphed into portable media players, adding video to their list of features. And all the while, prices have fallen drastically, so it's now not ridiculous to think of owning a device that will let you watch hours of movies on the go—or one that will let you click megapixel-resolution images, listen to music, FM, record video and audio, surf the Internet, check your e-mail, while still letting you make and receive phone calls!

We've seen the same trend in the digital camera segment, so much so that it almost makes no sense to even look at a film camera anymore. Entry-level cameras boast of features that were only available on the expensive, "high-end" cameras of just a couple of years ago.

Almost every urban Indian home bought a technology product in the past year, and this has prompted multinationals to flood the markets with a seeming embarrassment of choices in every category. Perhaps this is what makes this year's Zero1 Awards most significant.

Let's take a look at the crème de la crème of technology products that have won the Gold medals in our tests. Remember, no prizes for second place here!